50TH ANNIVERSARY

THE ODDBALLS
1995-2005

BIG BIZARRE

It was not only the miracles of technology that touched India. As unpoliced as the internet, human minds were increasingly seduced by the paranormal—Ganesha drinking milk, prehominids stalking Delhi...

GETTY IMAGES





AGE OF WEIRD India woke up to reports of Ganesha idols 'drinking' milk in Sept. 1995 (scientists cry capillary action); (left) Delhi's 'monkey man'; a film on the 'Onion Witch'



A strange duality tugged at the heart of new India. Modernity flooded the landscape, but deep within there lurked an atavistic ghost. The irrational made frequent visitations, most dramatically when Ganesha idols were said to be drinking milk all over the land one fine morning in 1995. Bizarre apparitions kept popping up across the decade. Y2K led to some millenarian doomsday fantasies. In 2001, the 'Monkey Man' menaced Delhizens: the police even released a sketch! Four years later, the Onion Witch stalked not just the capital but places as far afield as central India. The kindly lady, who was said to appear at the front door and make cut onions bleed, was honoured with a horror flick some years later. ■